

AP-20: FAI-Oblivious Restructuring

CKS Derivation Notes — Series D, Phase D3, Note D3.21 (#596)

Category 5: Perimeter and Content Failures (Closing Note)

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This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026) and “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

AP-20 formalizes the FAI-oblivious restructuring anti-pattern: a participating Self conducts aspect restructuring—creating, merging, or reorganizing aspects—based entirely on internal operational considerations while ignoring the governance intelligence that FAI participation has correctly produced. The Self has not failed at FAI participation, ingestion, or post-mortem review; it has failed at the final link: connecting that intelligence to structural governance decisions. This is the defining failure mode of Category 5 at the structural co-adaptation scope. The anti-pattern is an optimization failure, not an integrity failure, but it compounds across successive FAI events as structural boundary issues persist unaddressed. The governance prevention is explicit documentation in the restructuring record of which FAI-derived intelligence was considered and how it influenced the decision—a requirement that makes FAI-oblivious restructuring visible and therefore unacceptable.

1. Anti-Pattern Name and Category

AP-20: FAI-Oblivious Restructuring

Category 5—Perimeter and Content Failures. AP-20 is the fourth and final anti-pattern in Category 5 and closes the category. Where AP-17 through AP-19 addressed failures in how a participating Self manages its home perimeter content during and after FAI events, AP-20 addresses a distinct and more consequential failure: the structural co-adaptation cycle (D2.55) is broken at its final link, preventing

FAI-derived governance intelligence from reaching the structural decisions it was designed to inform.

2. Description

A participating Self has conducted FAI events correctly. It has contributed aspects to the shared substrate as required, applied the three-tier conflict-handling mechanism to inter-Self conflicts, generated post-mortem governance improvement records (D2.39) that document structural findings, and allowed preserved conflict carry-through annotations (D1.16) to enter its home action layer as flagged boundary issues. The evolution-feed machinery (Paper 3, Claim 4) has operated as designed: FAI-derived content has reached the Self's home Paper 2 evolution mechanisms. The post-mortem record contains governance improvement recommendations, some of which specifically flag aspect-boundary issues that the FAI event revealed.

Then the Self undertakes aspect restructuring—creating new aspects to handle emerging coordination domains, merging aspects whose functions have converged, or reorganizing the governance architecture of existing aspects. The governance reasoning for these decisions is drawn entirely from internal operational experience: throughput observations, resource allocation patterns, team feedback, coordination cost estimates. The post-mortem governance improvement records sit in the action layer. The FAI conflict carry-through annotations sit in the home substrate flagging boundary issues directly relevant to the restructuring decision. None of it is consulted.

The structural co-adaptation cycle (D2.55) specifies that FAI participation should feed, through the evolution machinery, into structural governance improvement. The cycle has four links: FAI event → evolution outputs → post-mortem governance improvement records → restructuring decisions. AP-20 breaks the fourth link. The first three links have operated correctly. The intelligence has been gathered, ingested, and converted into actionable records. It simply does not reach the decision that it was designed to reach.

This is not a failure of governance participation. It is a failure of governance utilization at the structural decision scope.

3. Detection Criteria

Four patterns indicate AP-20 is present:

Absent reference in restructuring records. Aspect restructuring governance records cite only internal operational experience—throughput data, coordination cost assessments, team input—with no reference to FAI post-mortem findings, FAI conflict carry-through annotations, or FAI-origin action-layer records. The record is internally coherent but structurally unaware.

Concurrent availability of relevant FAI intelligence. FAI events have occurred recently enough that their outputs remain in the action layer as post-mortem governance improvement records. The

restructuring decision is made while the intelligence is available but not while it is consulted.

Unreferenced conflict carry-through annotations. The home action layer contains FAI conflict carry-through annotations (D1.16) that flag boundary issues directly relevant to the restructuring domain—and the restructuring record does not reference them. The flags are present; the restructuring rationale does not acknowledge them.

Pending post-mortem recommendations. Post-mortem governance improvement records (D2.39) recommend specific restructuring changes that have not been implemented, while unrelated restructuring proceeds. The gap between recommended structural changes and actual restructuring decisions is a diagnostic indicator.

The most reliable combined signal is the third and fourth criteria together: conflict annotations flagging boundary issues in the restructuring domain that appear neither in the restructuring rationale nor in the list of considerations that the governance record documents as reviewed.

4. Governance Commitment Violated

Primary: Paper 2 structural co-adaptation commitment (C1.30). Paper 2 commits to structural adaptation driven by operational needs. FAI participation produces inter-Self governance intelligence about structural issues: which aspect boundaries generate coordination friction, which boundary arrangements persist as preserved conflicts across multiple events, which structural arrangements in partner Selves have produced observable coordination advantages. This intelligence is part of the operational needs context that structural co-adaptation is designed to incorporate. Conducting aspect restructuring without consulting it violates the spirit of C1.30 at the inter-Self governance intelligence scope.

Secondary: Paper 3 Claim 4—four-locus evolution feed. Claim 4 specifies that FAI events feed each participating Self's home evolution mechanisms through four architectural loci. The fourth locus—the action-feedback locus—is where FAI outcomes enter the home action layer as content that the action-feedback evolution mechanism processes into proposals for structural change. FAI-oblivious restructuring means the action-feedback locus is disconnected from structural improvement decisions: the content entered the layer correctly, but the restructuring governance process did not draw from it. The evolution feed's governance value at the action-feedback locus is not realized.

Operational reference: D2.55. The structural co-adaptation cycle explicitly names FAI-oblivious restructuring as the anti-pattern at the restructuring decision point. AP-20 formalizes the failure D2.55 identifies.

5. Consequences

Governance investment waste. FAI participation carries real governance costs: joint-event coordination, shared-substrate construction, conflict-handling governance, post-mortem review, evolution-feed ingestion. Each of these costs was paid in order to produce governance intelligence that improves the Self's governance architecture. When restructuring ignores that intelligence, the investment produces proposals that are never connected to structural decisions. The participation cost is paid; the governance improvement return is not collected.

Persistence of structural boundary issues. FAI events reveal, through conflict patterns (D2.07), which aspect boundaries generate coordination friction under inter-Self coordination conditions. If the restructuring process does not incorporate these findings, the boundary issues that generated the conflicts are preserved in the governance architecture. The next FAI event encounters the same boundary conditions and generates the same conflict patterns. The anti-pattern compounds: each FAI cycle adds conflict carry-through annotations flagging the same structural issues, and the restructuring record continues to ignore them.

Broken structural co-adaptation cycle. D2.55 specifies a complete cycle: FAI → evolution feed → post-mortem → restructuring. AP-20 breaks the last link. A broken last link means the cycle cannot complete, regardless of how well the preceding links operate. This is a systemic governance failure, not a local one—the break affects every restructuring decision made while the anti-pattern persists.

Compounding across FAI events. Unlike a single-event governance failure, AP-20 compounds. Each FAI event that produces post-mortem recommendations addressing structural issues that the Self's governance process then fails to incorporate adds to the unaddressed recommendation backlog. The gap between what FAI-derived intelligence recommends and what restructuring decisions reflect grows with each cycle. Eventually the gap becomes large enough that restoring the connection requires addressing accumulated backlog rather than simply incorporating the most recent findings.

6. Intra-Self Analog

The intra-Self analog is aspect restructuring that ignores action-feedback proposals generated from action-layer evidence. Paper 2 establishes that the action-feedback evolution mechanism produces proposals by operating over action-layer content—operational evidence of what is and is not working in the current governance architecture. The proposing substrate generates these proposals; the governance process accepts or rejects them. A Self that conducts aspect restructuring based entirely on governance instinct—without reviewing the action-feedback proposals that the mechanism has generated from operational evidence—commits the same failure at intra-Self scope that AP-20 commits at inter-Self scope.

In both cases: the evidence-gathering mechanism has operated correctly; the proposals are available; the structural decision ignores them. The difference is the source of the governance intelligence—internal action-layer evidence in the intra-Self case, FAI-derived inter-Self evidence in

the AP-20 case. The failure mode is identical. FAI-oblivious restructuring is the intra-Self action-feedback disconnect, extended to the inter-Self governance intelligence scope.

7. Resolution

D2.55's structural co-adaptation cycle is the architectural prevention. The cycle is not broken by the absence of FAI-derived intelligence—it is broken by the absence of a governance practice that connects available intelligence to restructuring decisions. The resolution is a governance practice requirement with three components.

Review of relevant conflict carry-through annotations. Before any aspect restructuring governance decision, the governance record should document which FAI conflict carry-through annotations (D1.16) in the home action layer are relevant to the restructuring domain, and what each annotation flags. This review does not require that the annotations drive the decision; it requires that the decision be made with knowledge of them.

Review of post-mortem governance improvement records. Post-mortem records (D2.39) that recommend restructuring changes relevant to the decision under consideration should be explicitly reviewed. Where a post-mortem recommendation aligns with the proposed restructuring, the record should note the alignment. Where it conflicts, the record should document the governance reasoning for proceeding despite the conflict or for deferring the post-mortem recommendation.

Explicit documentation in the restructuring record. The restructuring governance record should contain a section naming: which FAI-derived intelligence was reviewed, which post-mortem recommendations were considered, and how that intelligence influenced the restructuring decision. This documentation requirement is the governance prevention mechanism. It closes the anti-pattern by making FAI-oblivious restructuring visible: a restructuring record that lacks this section is a signal that the final link of the structural co-adaptation cycle was not connected.

The documentation requirement also functions as an accountability mechanism over time. When the same boundary issues appear in successive FAI conflict patterns, the governance record trail—post-mortem recommendations followed by restructuring records that document whether those recommendations were incorporated—provides a traceable history of structural governance decisions. That traceability is what allows governance practitioners to identify when a boundary issue has been repeatedly flagged and repeatedly deferred, and to escalate accordingly.

AP-20 closes Category 5. The category spans perimeter and content failures at the inter-Self coordination scope: failures of home perimeter maintenance during joint events, failures of content governance after events, and—at AP-20's scope—failure of the structural co-adaptation cycle that is designed to convert FAI participation into durable governance improvement. The correction does not require new architecture. It requires a governance practice that makes the final link of an

already-specified cycle non-optional.

Source Papers

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model: Extending the Coordination Knowledge Substrate Pattern to AI Selves under Human Governance*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

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